

internally distinct, they represent as many exemplars. Since exemplars must exist before any copies made from them, of necessity, and since many/most/(all?) of those exemplars must also have been based on distinct exemplars in their turn, even if someone were to allege a recension, it could not have been perpetrated later than the 8th century—simply impossible. Surely, because one must account for the geographical distribution.

Did someone concoct the $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ archetype in the 8th century? Who? Why? And how could it spread around the Mediterranean world? There are $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ MSS all over the place—Jerusalem, Sinai, Athens, Constantinople, Trikala, Kalavryta, Ochrida, Patmos, Karditsa, Rome, Sparta, Meteora, Venedig, Lesbos, and most monasteries on Mt. Athos (that represented different ‘denominations’), etc. [If there were six monasteries on Cyprus—one Anglican, one Assembly of God, one Baptist, one Church of Christ, one Methodist and one Presbyterian—to what extent would they compare notes? Has human nature changed?] But the Byzantine bulk ($\mathbf{K}^x$) controlled at least 60% of the transmissional stream ($\mathbf{f}^{35}$ = a. 18%); how could something concocted in the 8th century spread so far, so fast, and in such purity? How did it inspire such loyalty? Everything that we know about the history of the transmission of the Text answers that it couldn’t and didn’t. It is simply impossible that $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ could have been ‘concocted’ at any point subsequent to the 4th century. The loyalty with which $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ was copied, the level of loyalty for $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ being much higher than that for any other line of transmission, indicates that it was never ‘concocted’—it goes back to the Original.¹

And then there is the silence of history. Although I have already touched on this, it deserves specific attention. Allow me to borrow from my treatment of the ‘Lucianic Recension’.² John William Burgon gave the sufficient answer to that invention.

Apart however from the gross intrinsic improbability of the supposed Recension,—the utter absence of one particle of evidence, traditional or otherwise, that it ever did take place, must be held to be fatal to the hypothesis that it *did*. It is simply incredible that

¹ I have in mind an article that will take up the question of ‘level of loyalty’ and the ‘quality quotient’, comparing various lines of transmission on that basis. For example, why is it that an average $\mathbf{f}^{35}$ MS will have only one variant for every two pages of printed Greek text, while an average Byzantine bulk MS will have at least three variants per page, and an average Alexandrian MS will have over fifteen per page? Does that suggest anything about attitude, about taking one’s work seriously? By ‘attitude’ I mean specifically toward the exemplar being copied—was it an object of respect or reverence?

² *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV*, p. 84.